

has “IF this, THEN that” conditions. For example, it can easily be programmed in a smart contract that “IF Jack misses his flight and IF it was the airline’s fault, THEN the airline pays him the cost of the flight.” A vending machine is another commonly used example of a smart contract: “IF the user puts in enough money and IF the user types in the right code, THEN the user gets Doritos.” These conditions can become much more complex, creating conditional waterfalls depending on the process being programmed and the variables that need to be met.

While Szabo had the early vision for smart contracts, the Ethereum team would be the first to create a mainstream and attention-grabbing platform to execute smart contracts in a decentralized manner. At the core of the team is Vitalik Buterin, who many regard as Ethereum’s Satoshi.

Buterin was born in Russia but grew up in Canada. He had the good fortune of a freethinking father,² who in February 2011 introduced 17-year-old Buterin to Satoshi’s work and Bitcoin.³ Bitcoin had only been functioning for two years at that point, and no major alternative was in existence. It would not be until October of that year that Charlie Lee would release Litecoin.

It wasn’t long before Buterin fell down the Bitcoin rabbit hole. He quickly became one of the first well-known journalists pioneering the world of cryptoassets, even cofounding *Bitcoin Magazine*, which remains one of the best deep dive sites for technical analysis of blockchain architectures. While writing articles that merged sophisticated